

Rant 4: Happy Happy Year (Dec 2024)

For some reason, I find it difficult to write about my own experiences as they glow—seriously, organically glow without any of the luster so often imparted to us by myths of memory and movement. I *found* it stupid.

Looking back presently, superfluous details might also get in the way of truth. There exists no real need to sugarcoat my year because my year was pretty damn polarizing; a modern epic in its own right. I've safely endured the journey from sickness to life, which makes me incredibly happy-no-synonym.

Addition 1:

Perfection has long since run obsolete, run aground, and as trite as the “meaning of life and its subjectivity” discussion may be, taking philosophical agency—stamping the foot and admitting that pleasure feels *good*—cannot go unthought of.

In this lucid moment, I see no need to punish myself for pandering to ghosts and doing human things. I was once the stupid breed of child that would deprive themselves of food (water, even) at each perceived roadblock; sufferance made me a rock. I am still that stupid breed of child, but I recognize it now at least. I take enjoyment in stride, because flowers smell like scattered dreams and the world is much too long to while away.

Having grown up in some manner, jail time for past “sins” like drawing instead of studying and, good lord, *taking care of myself*, occurs to me an absolute waste of resources... so I haven't bothered. I've instead been exercising self-presence. Put simply, there is self-presence in catharsis; self-presence in riding the wave of frustration and overblown exhaustion and rabid fear until it crests on my shores, moaning; self-presence in the steady, living heartbeat by my ear and the nakedness of an evening spent with family-not-family. While the future does indeed worry me (I might very well be working a crappy job next summer with crappy coworkers and an ache in my crappy, swollen thumb again), I can't let the present rot away. I am obligated to preserve the present before the past as an archivist preserves stories before histories.

Parabolically speaking, she who slices her wrist at failure is no more successful than she who fails without theatrics.

My first midterm spat on me.

My last midterm reminded me that, no matter how badly I fear slipping, my fear will *always* be enough.

Addition 2:

I love people. I really, *really* love people.

Poets objectify nature, knowing full well lightning never stops for ducklings. In wrapping their heads around nature's vicissitudes, they ignore its fundamental neutrality. By the poeticized second law of thermodynamics, nature cannot be diminished, only transmuted into words befitting the various beauties, ruins, and ordinary tragedies of systems. Disrespectful language is not only that but plain wrong.

I love people, poets love nature, and I love...

People? Recursive stuff.

People are difficult, frustrating, touchy, and *would* be perfect if not for the stochastic arrangement of molecules belying their larger volatility. Evil, good, neither. Natural. Dividing human beings, much like drawing the line between storms and productive showers, doesn't do much for understanding. I will only relate so much as I know and have seen.

Sometime in June, I met several people who now share a bachelor pad in my heart. Sometime after, I met someone whose image lives beside them. Post-August, I learned why one cannot trap the entirety of the world's population in two hands, and why old friends are like butterflies in that they stress their agency when you forget it most.

I've made some bad, good, and alright memories. Some of note include spinning in a parking lot, exploring underground streets, seeing ghosts, and forgetting how to walk.

I've given up on a select few individuals.

The usual; the real.

Nothing beats the comfortable, weighted blanket heaviness of holding silence and realizing, with great foresight, that you'll miss the way the air feels on your cheeks. You'll lunge at the illusion of form pressed into a pillow, hair smothered between sheets—better yet, the holy bells of laughter, or worse yet, floodwater carving valleys into cheeksides. Thankfully clairvoyance is but a fleeting power, and the body cannot handle more than one sprinkling at a time.

I love
People.

End:

New years' resolutions suck. Why not just, you know, resolve goals before or after the arbitrary turning point?

There is some anthropological merit in ritualistic activity, I guess, so I'll give it a pass.

I henceforth resolve to:

- Keep my joints limber
- Read, despite all antagonistic forces
- Schedule appointments in a timely manner
- Learn which friends are worth catching up with
- Eat, drink
- Self-medicate more sparingly
- Keep studying (I'm never safe, even if work seems like second nature)
- Communicate

No point in specifying further. I can hold myself to these things... maybe.

Have a good evening.

Happy happy year!

Rant 3: International Baggage (March 2024)

The tough thing about writing, about being a writer, is seeing stories in people that you can't tell—*well*, you can tell them if you'd like, but there are likely legal ramifications to doing so. You also run the risk of them hating you forever. When I see tragedies, little bloody bits in the fabric of my family and world, I automatically run to the “let's write about this” track. There aren't many better ways to make sense of things.

Keeping my habit in mind, I talked to a certain someone a few days ago. A worldly someone. I talked to them about abnormal psychology (more specifically, cultural variations in symptoms), because disorders are all the rage these days. Some cultures don't call depression *depression*, I explained with the air of a wise teacher. By some cultures, I mean ours. More so yours, since I'm divorced from it. Bad move. I might as well have popped an insult, because I soon realized I'd spoken the obvious to a person who knew more about their country than me.

In their good graces, they heard me out anyway. For that I was grateful. At my core, I only wanted to stretch my scientific muscles and study for a class I didn't like. At my core, I had nothing to do with non-Western depressive symptoms—or did I?

Making sacrifices for younger people, teenagers toeing adulthood, is the sort of thing that should grant automatic sainthood. This time, their sacrifice was so great that I saw tears brimming in their eyes. Apparently, I'd forgotten about an experience that may or may not have come back to bite us both; a firsthand view of abnormal psychology at its worst.

There stands very much a divorce between the academic and personal sides of life. Back then I was so embroiled in DSMs and CCDs and ICDs and Freud, whatever he had to do with it, that a very real personal issue fell away from my case studies. It was like a drama; some foreign program I had no place watching. I stared from the sidelines like a bystander when the supporting lead's actress died, and to this day, I'm not entirely convinced that her death happened offscreen. Can you even die from the physical manifestation of worry, anyway? You can. It makes medical sense. Nonetheless, I couldn't shove our unique experience in the same box as my studies, and that was the issue.

So we sat in awkward pain for a bit. When my worldly companion first brought it up, saying “that's what happened to...”, we both fell apart. We cut away from each other like paper birds on a string and came spiralling down like helicopter seed pods, melting into the dirt like so. I heard some sniffing. Maybe I was sniffing. They apologised for mentioning a deeply personal problem, shoving their old burdens into something that was clearly meant to be detached, but I said it was okay. What else was I supposed to say? It's not okay? It's in the past and the past doesn't exist anymore?

They couldn't ever forgive the system, or the person manipulated by the system—the *culture*—for dismissing fatal struggles as a rough patch. And I couldn't ever forgive the confusing, roundabout world for placing me in between a rock (emotions) and a hard place (psychology). I just had to write about my tragedy.

Rant 2: Poem-Turned-Spiel-Turned-Warm-February-Day (Feb 2024)

Today I feel spring. I feel old trees, bark and overlapping wants, parents and loves and those who know best but can't say it right. I feel sticks in the grass and a hole in the mind, anthills especially. Half-asleep swans float down spring's inkflow. Certain things insist on staying where they are, and seasons love routine.

The strangest bit about seasons is their conflation of two opposites; ends and beginnings. Birth is tender but wrong without the other, and at the same time they *are* the other. Spring, I think, still lives in me. Keeps me green when nothing else will grow. I feel spring settling into every pore, my chest swells, I am proud. In all contradictions and things, I am awake. I make them one.

Oddly enough, I get the sense that a lot of me has changed, even while putting these words to paper. I'm not sure why. Maybe it's because, with reminders, I can finally see suns in the cold, take myself to the trees and throw my body down, offer every nail to them, then lay in their shade as thanks. I can power through arthritic twinges in my legs and remind myself very easily—logically, like a scientist—that life is worth living.

Spring, purveyor of these thoughts and writings, comes for me like an out-of-tune note. Its air has a lemon-drop tang to it, sliding through mud with wet hands, grabbing at grubs; convicted, so set on growth that every pot in the way shatters. I want this, ants, I want to sprout and I'm convinced I should. Here are so many things stamped in the clouds: Tree parents, a future I didn't try hard enough for, slipping out of my grasp just like so, peace before the big hill. Constancy.

I find myself different every day, in fact and step, but my hands fall into dirt just the same; always the right first, the left second, nailbeds full of fertiliser. One month, two months, three. Turn of the century. I always keep greens, swans, grasshoppers with great care; they're safe in my mind's eye. I write my pieces with fairy dust and pinecones on the margins, and sprinkle sweet starflowers over the page. Spring is a function of myself such that I can feel—and keep feeling all over, over, and over, becoming the season as it becomes me.

A-side:

“Need? What do I need?”

Honestly, what *anyone* needs is negligible -- a plot or two and some potting soil for the mind.

B-side:

“World peace?”

Winters aren't particularly good for the concept. They're sleep, work, and more sleep. Summers are alright, albeit a bit manufactured. A bit clean. Peace requires some blood at hand—and besides, when one chases after perfection, it lets them down. We deserve the messiness of animal ephemerality, organs spilling and all that. Not romance. Spring balances eating and being eaten, and as a result, reaches a happy medium.

Rant 1: The Chicago Rat Hole / Optimism (March 2024)

As of I'm-not-sure-when, there's been a great fuss over the Chicago rat hole. This aptly named rat hole is a hole in a Chicago sidewalk shaped like a rat.

Although the hole has purportedly existed since 2000, it only became "online popular" in 2024. Like most "online popular" things do, they force me to idealise the hell out of them—latching in some strange, unrelated way onto my own life.

I'm glad that I live ten minutes from a library. To Chicago residents who don't live about ten minutes from a library, where are they to visit when they need respite? There is work and there is home and there is a third, where you feel home but do not see it and slowly relearn why humans are pack animals. Oh, right! We're villages. We're *temples*.

The Chicago rat hole is a third place. It's not ersatz or makeshift, which I initially wanted to say. It's as real as they come. Watching people toss estradiol pills at the reverse-Pompeii ghost; scrolling past the collective dig-out after officials decided to fill the hole; seeing people make friends over something so unusual, I can't help but feel warm and fuzzy inside.

Why do I care so much about the rat hole? It's more than a third place, see; it's a good one. An authentic one. Real third places—lands truly absent of consumption, which is the real arthritis, an ache present in both the workplace and at home—must be free. Coffee shops beg for money, bars beg for tears, and libraries are the holy exception, but we can discuss those later (and how they're struggling, as all good things do).

The rat hole symbolises a tipping point. Craving the companionship and kind, albeit cultish behaviour we so often gravitate towards, the perfect non-religious idol exists in the form of a once-was. Tenderness towards once-wases indicates progress and, well, having enough time to spend on little, beautiful things that make us little, beautiful things. Because joy does not often mesh with legality, indicated by the rat hole's impromptu filling, I firmly believe that the tipping point in question is resilience at its peak against oppressive forces.

Rat fanatics catch the same thrill you feel when you're doing something—really, truly doing something, and the 24-hour handcuffs are wings instead of hindrances. Let's dig out this hole they filled with cement and throw our shovels in the air. Hell, let's work away from work. The Chicago rat hole is a break from the drone of over-and-over that so often plagues us these days. It also protests against lesser third spaces, exemplifying how humans will bond over cardboard and string.

To conclude, I hate passivity. I'm really glad to see others, quiet but convicted protestors, trash on passivity too. Ignoring how/why the hole appeared on my feed (probably due to a combination of nature, nurture, post-pandemic rot and incomprehensible algorithms), there is light at the end of the tunnel. Forcing the rat hole to transcend LCD and infect real life is difficult, but not impossible. I foresee an improvement in the distant future; a return to congregation. Preserving third places might be an acceptable first step.